AUTONOMIES

Master Essay Fine Art 2025

by

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Introduction

This is a story about an excavation of the a past where a crucial point in history meets the present, like an arrow that was fired a long time ago, only to pierce the heart of an artist called Liv Bildhuggare.
The story is about three generations of a search for Autonomy. One generation that escaped war – the next one escaping fascism and economic disaster – and the last generation escaping violence and abuse. The story talks about how to keep oneself together, despite all the cracks. An artform itself that could be called The Art of Surviving. An art performed by the people before Liv Bildhuggare, that had created footprints into the present and made her want to trace them backwards to understand herself and other people better.

The following text investigates through symbolic figures if it is possibile to grow from the roots or the crown, or if one must find another way.
This narrative also tells about a dance from another time that still shakes the earth warm and flat. About people who danced together, like in a wreath, towards death, as the only way to find freedom. This story is about Autonomy and Hardening. The hardening of the mind and the hardening of material. Autonomy, not in a political sense, but in the way an individual searches for self ruling.

This is a story about an artist searching her way.

You are soon about to read about the different scenes that metaphorically play out in the preparations for the solo exhibition *Dåets Ridå*, and inside the exhibitionroom.

Caracthers

DAWN

THE CHOIR

THE DICTATOR

LIV BILDHUGGARE

JANUS

SAPHO

ROZA

scene 1: Dawn and The choir about the Death dance (Thánati Lagemán)
scene 2: The dictators lamentation.
scene 3: Liv bildhuggare and The choir.
scene 4: Janus and Liv bildhuggare in a café.
scene 5: Sapho is visiting Liv bildhuggare in Stockholm, a studiovisit.
scene 6: Roza decides to revive herself and attend the exhibition.
scene 7: Epilogue, The choir breaking it down.

Scene 1 : Dawn and The choir about the death dance (Thánati Lagnemán)

Scenography: Olive oil, bay leaf, white sun, sharp stones.

Dawn walks out in the backyard where the other women are gathered. They have torn clothes and a sad look. Their hair is hanging loose or is braided. Gushes of tears shine on their dirty cheeks. Dawn focuses her gaze upwards, straight into the white sun.

DAWN
Last night I realised that my body is already dead. *Pause.* I have no sense in my body. *Pause.* My soul has flown away, high, high up where the skies are. *Pause.*
Last night I realised that the only way to survive, is to die. *Pause.*
They humiliate us, and they do it with pleasure. They rape us, with pleasure. And now they have killed the last of our beloved. They have taken everything from us. The only thing we have left today, when the sun shines white on us from the skies, is our lives. *Long pause.* I say, we take it before they do! *Raises voice.* Because they will! *Dawn has a blue fire running under her skin and around the conotures of her body. She fixates her eyes into the womens eyes.* Are you coming with me to the cliff of the mountain? Will you follow me to freedom?

THE CHOIR
We will follow you to freedom. We rather die than live this life, that is no life. We follow you to the edge of the cliff. We jump right out and die. Before they push us.

DAWN
We take each others hands. We dance until the earth is flat and warm.

THE CHOIR
We take each others hands. We dance until the earth is flat and warm. We dance and jump out from the edge. We dance out of the cliff. We are already dead. We cannot feel our bodies. Our souls are flying high, high up in the skies.

The women create a long wreath by holding hands. They dance to the rhythm of their song. They rock themselves to the right, left, right – one step forward. Stop. One right step back – they rock themselves to the left, right, left.
This way they slowly move, with contours of blue fire, towards the cliff of the mountain.

THE CHOIR
Sings. The eagle flew up. High up in the skies. If I were an eagle. If I were an eagle.

DAWN
Sings. The eagle flew up. High up in the skies. If I were an eagle. If I were an eagle.

When the women reach the top of the mountain they rock themselves to the right, left, right – then they jump from the cliff. One by one in the blue burning wreth, from the cliff they jump. They take their own lives.

Scene 2 : The Dictator's Lamentation

Scenography: Earth, dry, dusty, smell of meat, smell of garbage.

The Dictator enters through a wall of bricks that has walled in glass shards. He has exceptional pondus. He turns off all the lamps as he crosses the stage and sits down in a creaky chair. He takes a sip from his homemade liquor and raises his voice.

THE DICTATOR:
With a foreign dialect. As a child I lived in a house with a dirt floor.
We cooked food over open fire.
Four families were splitting two rooms.
Everyone in the house were my relatives.
One man was a jew.
Father helped him to hide
so that the nazis would not find him.
They saved his life.

We had coins hidden under a table top.
It was our only savings.
Father brought them when he fled.

I knew we would not make it
with only fathers salary.
So I started working too.

Already at eight I sold condoms
to the prostitutes at the harbor.
At eleven I worked at a candy factory.
After work, I went to school.
But I understood that we could not afford
me to continue at school.
So I started working full time.

I never learned how to write.
Not in my mother tongue
Not in any tongue.
It did not interest me.
Who needs writing skills
when you are hungry?

The house with the dirt floor
we lived in
was beside the railway station.
My father said we could steal
charcoal there.
To heat up the house.

On the other side
the neighbour had walled in
shards of glass.
So that we wouldn´t steal fruit
from their trees.

We lived during a military dictatorship.
You cannot understand
the meaning of that
if you weren´t there.
The abuse was effective.

I have been a commando soldier.
So I know, one thing or another.
I won all the prizes.
I was the fastest putting together a
Kalashnikov.
I made dinner for two thousand men.
Everybody wanted to be me.

But I didn´t want to stay in the country
that I called a rats nest.
I aimed for Sweden.
There I could find someone to marry.
Create a worthy life.

I came to Sweden in 1974.
They threw me out many times.
I had to think of a permanent way to stay.
I was determined to never return
regardless of what I had to do.

During my first months in Stockholm
I slept in T-centralen.
I was many times physically abused by nazis.
But it only made me stronger.

I married a swedish woman
as an agreement.
I got my swedish passport.
I could finally start my life
work an economy
to be safe.
To be free.
Autonomous.

Scene 3 : Liv Bildhuggare and the Choir

Scenography: A pitch black portal. A pitch black room.

The only thing that one can see is shadow like faces. No bodies. Sometimes it crackles like electricity. Then the bodies that belong to the faces are visible, with a lot of holes.

THE CHOIR
Economical freedom is the only true freedom.

LIV BILDHUGGARE
I wish that I could be free in another way, maybe spiritually.

THE CHOIR
Economical freedom is the only true freedom.

LIV BILDHUGGARE
With eyes closed. I have to go against everything! Otherwise I will go mad. Otherwise I will get sucked in to this black hole. *Electricity crackles.* You are not even human. I will never do what you want, I will always do the opposite. *Speaking carefully.* You can hit me as much as you want, it doesn´t hurt anymore. *With confidence.* You can hit me as much as you want, I will always do the opposite.

THE CHOIR
You will never be free. You will never be free.

Scene 4 : Liv Bildhuggare and Janus talking in a café.

Scenography: Outdoors café, Swedish summer, toasted bread and ruccola.

Liv Bildhuggare sits and reads her book and drinks coffee (she reflects romantically upon her being in that moment). Janus sits with a tables distance from her and reads his book.

JANUS
What are you reading?

LIV BILDHUGGARE
Looks at the cover of her book. Eros the Bittersweet by Ann Carson. What about you?

JANUS
The Artist as Ethnographer by Hall Foster.

LIV BILDHUGGARE
Oh, yeah I have read that one.

JANUS
I hope I´m not disturbing you but. *Pause.* What did you think about the text?

LIV BILDHUGGARE
Waves with her hands. No, not at all. Pause. I got affected by the text since I am an artist and second generation of immigrants in Sweden. And maybe I´m working a bit on the topic of ethnograpgy, or diaspora, but it felt a bit in the text like that´s not a positive thing. So I got a bit uncomfortable. *Pause.* But, I also think that it´s not so strange that artists nowadays are interested in ethnography since many of us belong to a diaspora from different parts of the world. I guess we are searching for something in the past that can help to define us as people in this other context.

JANUS
Yes. *Pause.* The past can say a lot about who we are, but not everything. The future also holds many possibilities. Things that can break up all that pressed matter. Break up and set free. *Takes some sips of coffee and looks straight forward.* And what about your book, what is it about?

LIV BILDHUGGARE
I really recommend this one. She writes about the many different ways the god Eros is working. As the title suggests, it´s precisely the Bittersweet she talks about. In greek it´s called Glykópikron. She handles different topics through a lens of the bittersweet state. And I really admire her sense of creativity, knowledge and ability to see the bigger perspective. *Pause.* As an example she writes, can I read out loud?

JANUS
Smiles. Absolutely.

LIV BILDHUGGARE
Reads from the book. ”The blind spot of Eros is a paradox in time as well as in space. A desire to bring the absent into presence, or to collapse far and near, is also a desire to foreclose ”then” upon ”now – You cannot want that, and yet you do.”*Pause.* Interesting, right? Anyway. *Laughs.* Excuse me, I got a bit worked up. Tell me about you. What do you work with?

JANUS
No worries at all, I can really relate to those questions. I do work as guard. That means. *Pause.* I guard the portal between the past and the future.

LIV BILDHUGGARE
Wow! *Very impressed.* That sounds very exciting. So, what do you do exactly?

JANUS
Well, I represent different dualities when they meet. For example Life and Death, War and Peace. You could say that I am the breaking point between different courses of events.

LIV BILDHUGGARE
It sounds like I should have chosen that path instead of being an artist. Sometimes it´s so painful to make art. But I´m sure it´s painful to be a guard too.

JANUS
Yes, it really is. *Pause.* Well, I´m gonna continue reading.

LIV BILDHUGGARE
Me too. *Smiles. Pause.* It was nice talking to you.

JANUS
Smiles. The same to you!

Scene 5 : Sapho visits Liv Bildhuggare in Stockholm, studiovisit.

Scenography: Liv Bildhuggare and Sapho sits on computer chairs with a cup of black coffee each. We dive directly into their conversation about the solo exhibition, autonomy and the dance.

LIV BILDHUGGARE
One day I realised I was standing on a plateau of my lifetime, looking at my memories like artefacts. Objects frozen in time. For every passing year they got dustier and dustier.
Until unrecognizable because of their foggy veil.
And now. *Pause.* I have stepped into this spectacle. Like a museum of my life. *Long Pause.* The ringdance that I have depicted in some of my work is a central topic. The dance is a Pondian folkdance from The Black Sea, Anatolia, where my ancestors are from. It´s called Thánati Langemán and It´s about the around twenty women that jumped out from a cliff and comitted suicide because they were raped and abused and treated like slaves by the men of the Ottoman empire. They took their life in their own hands so to speak. Me, as a teenager I was going to Pondian folkdance school in Rinkeby where I used to dance and perform this dance, among other dances.

SAPHO
Yes, I know about the Pondian people. It is nice to see that their culture has been carried on even though such a long time has passed, and despite the genocide! I understand this is an important topic for you.

LIV BILDHUGGARE
Yes. *Pause.* To dance like that, together. *Pause.* To form a wreath of people, that hand in hand rock themselves synchronized to the rhythem of a drum or a lyre is for me the ultimate way to transend myself. *Pause.* To reach ecstacy together. *Pause.* This is a way to bring the elastic history forward, to the present. To pass on a legacy that is hidden behind the curtain of the past.
Long pause. Liv looks out from the window. I believe it becomes very important for people fleeing war or people that somehow are being displaced, to strengthen their cultural identity, like with the ringdance. It´s a way to first grieve collectivly and then lead way for healing. *Long pause.*

SAPHO
Interesting. Dance and sorrow somehow belong together. *Pause. Sapho takes notes.* And you use the term Autonomy a lot when you talk about your art, right?

LIV BILDHUGGARE
Yes, exactly, I connect the term Autonomy, self ruling, to the story of the dance, but also to my own search for autonomy. I see the different works in my solo exhibition as forms of autonomy. In one painting there is a figure that protects itself from ”higher powers”. *Liv gesticulates with her arms to protect her body.* I think it´s about a person that got beaten up as a child and later as an adult still tries to protect himself from the evil forces that actually, no longer are there.

The figure is trying to rise, but can´t because of the echo of threats and violence. *Pause.* Another work is a limestone plastered painting that shows a gigantic hand that pulls hard on an ankle. The title is "The past grabbing on". *Pause.* A way of portraying the feeling of walking in circles in the path of self-realization.

SAPHO
I understand. *Pause.* You mentioned limestone plaster, can you tell a bit more about the material and the technique?

LIV BILDHUGGARE
I was introduced to this technique first when I was working in the construction industry as a decor plasterer. The technique is called Tadelakt and derrives from an ancient plastering tradition in Morocco. It involves that one presses the lime plaster for a long time until it gets hardened. Like a stone again.

SAPHO
And what is it that interests you about that?

LIV BILDHUGGARE
I guess that it is about the hardening process. I like to draw parallels between the material hardening and the psycological hardening. *Pause.* When a person is exposed to violence for a long time, they have to harden to survive. When the person is processed enough you can hit them without them cracking. Like a stone. Hitting only hurts the hitter.
If one is not hardened enough, a person can crackelate, break completely and fall down in a pile of dust. Sometimes a person can live a whole life with cracks without falling down in a dustpile. *Long pause.* I feel when I work with the plaster that I am working so that the sorrow won´t stay inside me, but in the work instead. *Pause.* Sometimes I work like I am taking revenge, like I am crashing. *Pause.* The material has taught me that one can crack without breaking into pieces.

SAPHO
Yes. *Pause. Small smile.* I just want to mention my poems that I think only got more beautiful with the hand of time. It has been more than two thousand years since I wrote them. But the cracks, or, the missing parts, only enhance the beauty of the work. Time does something that I could never make myself. My advice is to not get too stuck in the hardening of things and look at what is broken as something beautiful and transcendet. *Sapho looks at Liv to see her reaction. Liv sits sunken into thought.* Do you want to explain a bit about what the Rembetika is and what it means to you?

LIV BILDHUGGARE
Wakes up from her contemplations and answers. Rembetika is a music genre. A sort of Greek gangster blues from the 1920's. As a result of the genocide and the burnings in Smyrma, todays Izmir, this underground culture emerged. The music grew strong, especially in Athens. They sing about decadence, criminal life, violance, poverty, but also about enjoying life and the wonders of it.The songs mirror the duality between misery and happiness, and all their intangible shiftings.

This is something that I really miss alot in Swedish culture. I mean, to allow the of expression negative feelings, without it being negative. There is always something positive in the negative. But in Sweden, the consensus is to not express the negative. We rather surpress it. *Pause.* The Rembetika anyways, is something that always has touched me. It´s like the music sets the tone for my art. That´s why I want to have a Rembetiko clarinet player in my solo exhibition. To activate the lamentation. *Long pause.* In the music one can also draw a parallel to ornamentation. I think about how during the baroque period they started building the churches so that the facades standed out a bit with the help of ornaments. It was mostly a gesture to lure in people to the church in a time where religion started to get replaced by science. A bit like what I want to do with my reliefs. I want to lure the observer into the picture. I try to make an aesthetic, maybe political point, meanwhile telling a story.
Sapho nods, looks at her watch and informs that she has to go to another meeting. She leaves the room with a promise to keep in touch.

scene 6 : Roza decides to revive herself and join the exhibition stage.

Scenography: Galleri Konstfack, dim but dramatic light, scent of cypress, reliefs on the walls, stone-looking sculptures.

A Clarinet player has just finished crying into his clarinet and the audience is applauding. When Roza enters, a ring is formed around her. She is wearing a golden velvet evening dress with a 1920s style. A Canón starts to tremble in sync with a baglamás. Her beautiful voice cuts a wound in the room and people fall into a trance. (Authors translation of the song "Mana mou ellás" by Stavros Xarchakos)

ROZA
Aaaaaaaaaahhh, aman, amaaaaaaaaaan,
aman aman aaaamannnnnnn...

Αααααααααααχ, αμάν, αμάάάάάάάάάν
αμάν, αμάν αααμάνννννν...

I don´t have a home to go home to
nor a bed to sleep in
I don´t have a street or neighborhood to walk
not even to go the 1st of May

Δεν έχω σπίτι πίσω για να'ρθώ
ούτε κρεβάτι για να κοιμηθώ
δεν έχω δρόμο ούτε γειτονιά
να περπατήσω μια Πρωτομαγιά.

Those fake, grand words
you fed me with your mother's milk
now that the snakes are awake
you're wearing your ancient adornments
and you never weep, Mother Greece
though you sell your children like slaves

Τα ψεύτικα τα λόγια τα μεγάλα
μου τα 'πες με το πρώτο σου το γάλα.
Μα τώρα που ξυπνήσανε τα φίδια
εσύ φοράς τα αρχαία σου στολίδια
και δε δακρύζεις ποτέ σου μάνα μου Ελλάς
που τα παιδιά σου σκλάβους ξεπουλάς.

Those fake, grand words
you fed me with your mother's milk
and when I spoke to my fate
you wore your finery
and took me to the market like the monkey of a gypsie
Greece, Greece, mother of suffering

Τα ψεύτικα τα λόγια τα μεγάλα
μου τα`πες με το πρώτο σου το γάλα.
Μα τότε που στη μοίρα μου μιλούσα
είχες ντυθεί τα αρχαία σου τα λούσα
και στο παζάρι με πήρες γύφτισσα μαϊμού
Ελλάδα Ελλάδα μάνα του καημού.

Those fake and grand words
you fed me with your mother's milk
but now that the fire rages again
You look at your ancient beauty
and in the world arena, mother Greece
you will always carry the same lie

Τα ψεύτικα τα λόγια τα μεγάλα
μου τα 'πες με το πρώτο σου το γάλα.
Μα τώρα που η φωτιά φουντώνει πάλι
εσύ κοιτάς τα αρχαία σου τα κάλλη
και στις αρένες του κόσμου μάνα μου Ελλάς
το ίδιο ψέμα πάντα κουβαλάς.

A blue shimmering tear marks a stripe on Rozas cheek as she turns around and walks out from the exhibition scene. Applauses and damped screams are heard from the audience.

Scene 7: Epilogue

Scenography: A dark stage with night sky blue stage curtains. A spotlight shines on one of the members from the choir.

The choir dances the dance from the past, very slowly, in the shadows, close to the night sky blue curtain. Only damp noises can be heard from the bouncing feet. It sounds like a clock or a humming lullaby.

THE CHOIR

And what Liv Bildhuggare had learned
was it´s hard to take reality serious
no matter how her thoughts turned
reality was always mysterious

And that was why she made this play
to be able to connect with the world
maybe to someone this isn´t a game
but it was the way her heart swirled

She did not belong to the theatre
just to the spectacle of life
she wanted to be a creator
and not involving in strife

Her art was not only scenography
It was also narrating her history
It is a sort of biography
but also ancient objects of artistry

The characters were carefully chosen
Liv Bildhuggare was just a representation
to show opinions, a bit like posing
Liv was a piece of imagination

The Dictator was not really lamenting
in real life he was her father
he was proud and strong but tormenting
her life since a kid, it was awful!

Janus was there to provide
a symbol for us to reflect
Sapho was human but she already died
symbols aren´t real but they have an effect

Roza was put in the play
she was always an inspiration
she was really here to stay
she sang about life and the nation

Dawn was just a way to tell
a story never heard at Konstfack
a story the artist knows too well
but never had the chance to unpack

The Choir is us, and we tell this story
of an artist who´s name means the opposite of die
it´s just for fun and all art's glory
at last we say thank you and good bye!

The End!

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Zoi Johansson
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